DBQ Point Guide 4: Evidence Beyond the Documents

Oct 28, 2026 · @CJ DeRuyter

What the rubric requires

The outside-evidence point (Row C, 1 pt) goes to one specific, accurately described piece of historical evidence not found in the documents that helps an argument about the prompt.

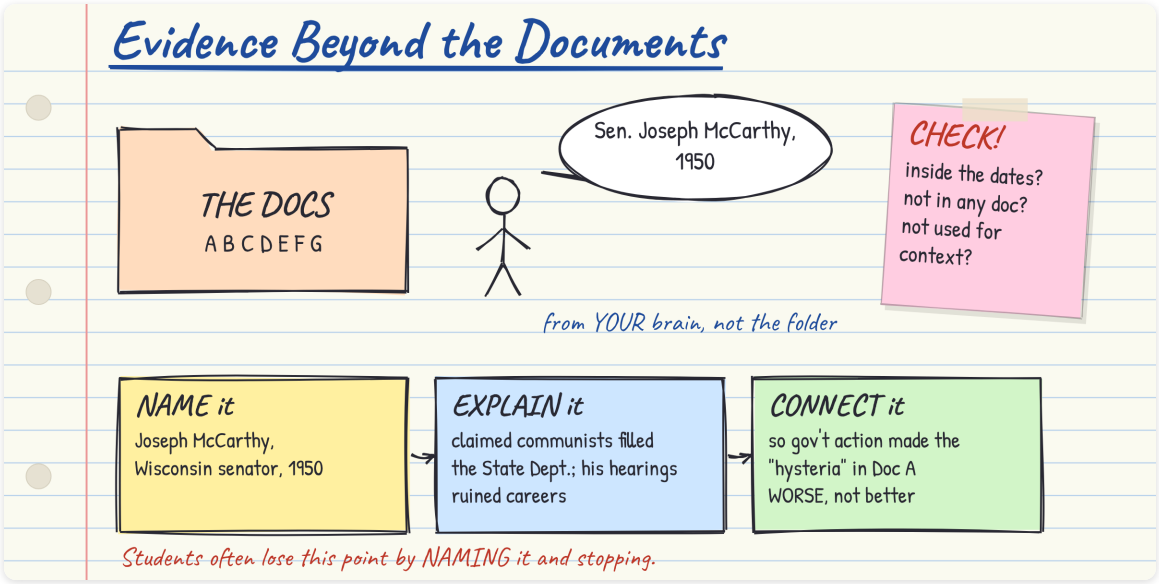
Five conditions, all required:

1. **Specific.** A named law, person, event, court case, or organization. College Board notes that evidence is typically *more* specific than context.
2. **Described.** More than a phrase or reference: say what it was or did.
3. **Inside the time frame and region.** 2024 Set 1 Sample 1B's *Uncle Tom's Cabin* (1852) and Sample 1C's *Dred Scott* (1857) were rejected for a 1783–1840 prompt.
4. **Not already in the prompt or documents.** Elaborating on something a document already says doesn't count.
5. **Tied to an argument.** It has to support a claim, not float as trivia.

It must also be a **different** piece of evidence from whatever earned contextualization. It can appear anywhere in the essay, and one solid example is enough.

The foolproof formula

Plant **two** pieces of outside evidence in the body paragraphs (one is required; the second is insurance), each written as a **Name** → **Describe** → **Connect** set:



1. **Name it** with a proper noun and, ideally, a date: "the McCarran Internal Security Act of 1950."
2. **Describe it** in one sentence: what it did or what happened.
3. **Connect it** to the paragraph's claim: "This shows…"

> Frame: "Another example is [specific name, year], which [what it did]. This shows [link to claim]."

Rules to drill:

- **Brainstorm before writing.** During planning, list 3–5 outside names per body paragraph, then cross off anything that appears in a document or falls outside the dates.
- **Check the dates.** If unsure whether an event is inside the time frame, leave the year off rather than writing a wrong one; 2024 Set 1 Sample 1C got credit for an undated Fugitive Slave Act because it could be read as the 1793 law.
- **Keep context and evidence separate.** Context = before or around the prompt, in the introduction. Evidence = inside the argument, in the body.
- **Put it next to a document.** Pairing outside evidence with a document ("Like Dulles in Document B, the Eisenhower Doctrine…") also helps toward complexity.

Cold War options (prompt is roughly 1945–1961; check none duplicates Docs A–G): Truman Doctrine, Marshall Plan, NATO, NSC-68, Korean War, Loyalty Review Board, HUAC and the Hollywood Ten, McCarthy and the Army-McCarthy hearings, the Rosenberg trial, Sputnik and NASA, "duck and cover" drills, Eisenhower's massive retaliation.

Examples that earned the point

Source	Outside evidence	Why it earned the point
2025 Set 1, Sample 1A (score 7)	Lyndon Johnson's Great Society, with its War on Poverty and Medicare	Named program, two specifics, and used to show federal involvement continued after Kennedy (Doc 4).
2025 Set 2, Sample 1A (score 7)	Growth of sharecropping after the Civil War	Used as an example of negative economic and social change, supporting the "mixed effects" argument.
2024 Set 1, Sample 1B (score 6)	William Lloyd Garrison advocating emancipation “without compromise”	Credited because it was discussed separately from Doc 5. The same essay's *Uncle Tom's Cabin* (1852) was outside the time frame and didn't count.
2024 Set 2, Sample 1C (score 3)	“During world war two the US was nuetral, despite having helped its previous allies Britian through the Lend Lease act…”	One specific, described sentence earned the point in a 3-point essay.
2024 Set 2, Sample 1B (score 5)	Isolationism before both world wars	A concept, not a single event, but credited because the essay “effectively elaborates upon what isolationism entailed.”
2023 Set 1, Sample 1B (score 4)	Eli Whitney's cotton gin and its effect on the growth of slavery	Classic Name → Describe → Connect.

2023 Set 2, Sample 1B (score 5)	The 14th Amendment granting citizenship after the Civil War	Specific, accurate, and central to the citizenship argument.

College Board model sentence (2025 Set 1):

> "Lyndon B. Johnson's Great Society further expanded the federal government's role in the economy by creating government programs to fight poverty."

Cold War model (written for this guide):

> "The government also fed fears at home. In 1950 Senator Joseph McCarthy claimed that communists had infiltrated the State Department, and his hearings ruined careers on little evidence. This shows that some government efforts to fight subversion increased the 'hysteria' Eisenhower describes in Document A rather than easing it."

Examples that did not earn the point

Failure type	Example	Why it fails
Outside the time frame	2024 Set 1, Sample 1C: *Dred Scott* (1857) for a 1783–1840 prompt; Sample 1B: *Uncle Tom's Cabin* (1852)	Accurate history, wrong dates. Readers check.
None offered	2025 Set 1, Sample 1B (score 5): strong documents and sourcing, but every piece of evidence came from the documents	The most common miss. Even a 5-point essay lost it.

Only document content	2025 Set 2, Sample 1C: "the evidence utilized is drawn exclusively from the documents"	Re-explaining a document, however well, is not outside evidence.
No attempt	2023 Set 1 and Set 2, Sample 1C	No names beyond the documents.
Passing reference	"…like the New Deal." with nothing more	A label without description; College Board lists items like the New Deal as creditable only "if appropriate elaboration is provided."
Repeats the documents	Describing Kennedy's "pay any price" pledge (Document E) as outside evidence	It's in the documents.
Same as context	Using the 1949 Soviet atomic test for both context and outside evidence	One piece of evidence can earn only one of the two points.

Cold War non-examples (written for this guide):

- “McCarthyism made people scared.” Named, but not described.
- “The Cuban Missile Crisis showed how scary the Cold War was.” Specific, but 1962 is past most of the documents' range; tie it explicitly to the argument or choose an earlier event.
- “The interstate highways were built for defense.” Already in Document D.

Expert tips

The standard advice is the same three moves as above: **Name** → **Explain** → **Connect**. Readers see the point lost most often because students "can usually name a piece of evidence, but then they forget to explain it or connect it."

- **Placement:** anywhere it fits the argument. A lead-in such as "Another piece of evidence related to this is…" works in the body paragraph where it belongs.
- **Handle it like a document:** name it, explain it, then show how it proves the argument.

Rubric note: staying inside the time period is often taught as a rule of thumb, but the current College Board scoring guidelines are explicit: "evidence that is outside the time period or region specified in the prompt" does not earn the point (2024 Set 1 lost credit for *Dred Scott* and *Uncle Tom's Cabin*). Treat it as a requirement.

Grader checklist

Scan the body paragraphs for proper nouns that don't appear in any document. For each candidate:

1. Is it specific (a name, law, event, case, organization), or a concept elaborated in detail?
2. Is it described in at least a full clause, not just named?
3. Is it accurate and inside the prompt's time frame and region?
4. Is it absent from the prompt and all seven documents?
5. Does it support a claim in the argument?
6. Is it different from the evidence credited for contextualization?

One candidate with six yeses = 1 point.

Feedback stems for students

- Earned: "[Evidence] earns the outside-evidence point because you explained what it was and how it supports your claim."
- Not earned (none): "Add one specific example not in the documents, such as [suggestion], and explain how it supports your paragraph."
- Not earned (phrase only): "You mention [term]. Add a sentence saying what it was and how it connects to your argument."